



Spring 2026

The White Collar Times

*The official newsletter of the American Society of Criminology
Division of White-Collar and Corporate Crime*

Message from the Executive Board

Hello DWCC,

The DWCC Executive Board is happy to share the latest member news, publications, and Division updates in this spring 2026 edition of *The White-Collar Times*.

The DWCC Student Book Club is currently reading its fourth book, a first-hand account of a prosecutor seeking criminal punishment for a doctor's illegal prescriptions in Charlotte Bismuth's "Killer in a White Coat: The True Story of New York's Deadliest Pill Pusher and the Team that Brought Him to Justice." There are five students in the group, which has increased with each book. The next group will begin in the fall, welcoming both new and returning members.

Beginning last summer, we re-established our Division mentoring program, pairing four senior scholars with four students. The mentorship pairings decided on their own activities and agendas. Our students have been involved in the research and publication processes, participated in events, and received advice on dissertations and other classroom assignments. We are seeking to expand the program this year. Keep an eye out for more information if you are interested in participating as mentor or mentee.

As we approach fall, we will ramp up our initiatives associated with the annual ASC conference. We will be putting out our annual call for awards nominations in the coming weeks, giving awards for the Gilbert Geis Lifetime Achievement Award, David O. Friedrichs Teaching Award, The Young Career Award, The Student Paper Award, the Outstanding Book Award, and the Outstanding Article or Book Chapter Award. We would like to thank the committee of Katelyn Golladay, Yuliya Zabyelina, and Hei Lam Chio for their help with the awards process. Keep an eye on your email for more information.

Of course, the biggest Division events are in November. The ASC annual conference will be held in Chicago, IL, from November 18-21. The Division plans to have a number of sponsored panels and roundtables, as well as a general business meeting and awards ceremony, full Division social, and a student social. Our committee of Miranda Galvin, Megan Parker, Mike Maume, and Marina Zaoznaya are seeing that we have a great conference. We will provide more details about the Division events closer to November.

We are currently seeking help to create an all-new format for *The White-Collar Times*! The first newly revised issue will be prepared in October/November. If you are interested in assisting with designing and constructing the newsletter, please email ehomer@acfe.com.

We wish you a joyful spring and summer, and look forward to connecting with you in the fall!

-The Executive Board

ASC DWCC Organization

Chair: Emily M. Homer

Vice Chair: Katelyn Golladay

Secretary/Treasurer: Yuliya Zabyelina

Executive Counselor: José Atiles

Executive Counselor: Hei Lam Chio

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Evidence-based anti-corruption oversight: Stop counting activity, start measuring consequences

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Anti-corruption oversight fails in a familiar way: institutions optimize what they can easily count. We count how many written questions legislators file, how many replies arrive, and whether a deadline was met. But corruption does not retreat because oversight exists on paper—it retreats when oversight changes behavior: procurement is corrected, audits are triggered, sanctions occur, contracts are cancelled, and service delivery improves.

Written legislative requests for information (RICs and functional equivalents) expose the core measurement gap between procedural activity and substantive accountability. Cross-national variation in activity is real: in 2024, Brazil's Chamber of Deputies recorded 4,698 written questions and 4,382 answers; Portugal's Assembly, 1,363 questions and 941 answers; Poland's Sejm, 8,762 questions and 11,174 answers; the UK House of Commons, 41,914 questions and 41,716 answers; and New Zealand's House of Representatives, 81,347 questions and 81,302 answers.

Those totals are not directly comparable measures of "oversight performance." Some jurisdictions explicitly note definitional and counting issues (e.g., New Zealand's figures include both oral and written questions; the UK notes questions are typically tracked by parliamentary session rather than calendar year; Poland notes replies can exceed questions because multiple departments may reply). The point of reporting the numbers is not to rank legislatures. It is to show why activity-based indicators, by themselves, are a weak and sometimes misleading basis for assessing scrutiny, accountability, or integrity outcomes.

An evidence-based approach starts by treating oversight as a measurable intervention with a theory of change. The core question is not "How many questions were filed?" but: **"What causal pathway did those questions activate—and for whom?"**

Five empirical questions determine whether oversight is real or symbolic.

1) Do information requests change executive behavior—or mostly manufacture compliance?

This is the first-order question: do RICs alter outcomes that matter (contract cancellation, audit activation, enforcement action, budget reallocation, regulatory revision, corruption exposure, service-delivery improvement), or do they mostly generate symbolic accountability?

Evidence-based oversight requires moving from descriptive dashboards to causal inference:

- **Link each request** to downstream administrative events (procurement records, audit openings, disciplinary actions, payment suspensions, renegotiations, court referrals, program outputs).
- **Estimate impact** against a credible counterfactual (matching, event studies, difference-in-differences around rule changes, discontinuities where thresholds exist, synthetic controls where panel structure allows).

If oversight cannot demonstrate downstream effects, it becomes vulnerable to a predictable equilibrium: legislators ask questions for visibility; executives reply minimally to close the file; institutions reward "responsiveness" rather than truth.

2) "Answered" is not the same as "answered": the evasion problem

Most official statistics track whether an answer exists—not whether it addresses the question. That creates an accountability loophole: governments can appear compliant while evading scrutiny through vagueness, omission, strategic over-technicality, or non-responsiveness. Evidence-based oversight needs a quality metric, not only a timeliness metric.

A practical standard is hybrid scoring:

- **Computational scoring** of relevance, specificity, factual density, and internal consistency.
- **Grounding checks** against administrative data (does the answer align with procurement databases, budget execution, audit registers?).
- **Human validation** using expert-coded samples to calibrate the metric across time and agencies.

Without a quality score, incentives drift toward the lowest-cost equilibrium: answers optimized to minimize exposure and workload, not to maximize accountability.

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3) Who benefits from oversight: citizens, organized interests, or electoral constituencies?

Even when oversight works, it may work unevenly. The distributional question is whether RICs direct scarce state attention toward broad public-interest failures—or toward donors, local elites, sectoral lobbies, and electorally strategic grievances. Evidence-based oversight must test heterogeneous returns:

- Connect question text and sponsorship to electoral geography, campaign finance, sectoral concentration, procurement winners, local media markets, and social vulnerability.
- Estimate whether response quality and corrective actions differ systematically for connected vs. high-need groups.

If oversight reliably yields faster, higher-quality answers for connected actors, it becomes a mechanism that can reproduce privilege rather than constrain corruption.

4) Oversight is a system: complements vs. substitutes across watchdog institutions

A persistent analytical error is isolating one tool as if it operates alone. Written questions coexist with hearings, audit institutions, ombuds offices, FOI regimes, courts, investigative journalism, and internal controls. The unresolved empirical issue is whether RICs:

- Complement other institutions (trigger audits, generate evidence trails, enable enforcement, catalyze media scrutiny), or
- Substitute for them (symbolic action that displaces higher-cost scrutiny without improving accountability).

Evidence-based design models sequences, not snapshots:

question → answer → media pickup → audit → sanction → correction → service outcome

The goal is an accountability “production function”: which combinations of tools produce measurable integrity outcomes, and where investment has the highest marginal return.

5) Institutional design for resilience under executive dominance and democratic stress

The toughest test for oversight is not routine governance—it is executive dominance, coalition incentives that dilute scrutiny, and democratic stress that erodes enforcement. Evidence-based design treats reforms as testable hypotheses:

- When rules change (deadlines, publication requirements, sanctions for non-response, committee powers, minority rights), measure pre/post shifts in:
 - timeliness and answer quality,
 - repeat questioning (a symptom of evasion),
 - downstream corrective action,
 - and—critically—service delivery metrics in affected domains.

The test is not whether reforms “look good.” It is whether they strengthen the chain from information to correction.

What “evidence-based oversight” looks like in practice

An evidence-based anti-corruption oversight system is an operating model:

- Define outcomes, not outputs:** audits triggered, sanctions applied, procurement corrected, budgets reallocated, service delivery improved—not merely questions filed.
- Build the data spine:** a traceable dataset linking request text, answer text, timing, responsible agency, and downstream administrative events.
- Measure evasion:** answer-quality metrics that detect non-responsiveness disguised as compliance.
- Test distribution:** identify whether oversight benefits are skewed toward connected actors or toward vulnerable communities.
- Model interactions:** quantify how questions interact with audits, FOI, courts, and media to produce accountability.
- Use reforms as experiments:** evaluate institutional changes using credible causal designs, not intuition.

Counting activity is easy; proving effectiveness is hard. Evidence-based oversight is the decision to do the hard part—because public resources, trust, and democratic legitimacy are too expensive to manage by intuition.